

Chapter 165-1

In the middle of the night, Liang Shi was woken up by Zhao Xuning's phone call.

Liang Shi glanced at Xu Qingzhu beside her, who was only frowning slightly, made restless by the ringtone. Liang Shi first muted her phone, then patted Xu Qingzhu's back and tiptoed out of bed to answer the call.

After the call connected, all she could hear was the howling sound of wind.

Liang Shi asked her, "Where are you?"

After a long while, Zhao Xuning finally said, "Look down from upstairs."

Liang Shi immediately walked to the window and looked down. On the Yujiang Bridge, there was a white figure—actually just a small white dot.

Looking from the tenth floor, she could barely see more than a speck of light.

But inexplicably, Liang Shi just knew it was Zhao Xuning.

All her drowsiness vanished at once. She hurriedly threw on a coat and headed out. "What are you doing?"

There was no response from Zhao Xuning's end.

The sounds of traffic and wind burrowed into Liang Shi's ears.

Zhao Xuning said, "Don't come out."

Liang Shi frowned. "Are you drunk?"

She was already stepping into the elevator as she spoke.

"I'm fine," Zhao Xuning said.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, wanting to say that she really didn't sound fine at all.

Even though Zhao Xuning told her not to come down, Liang Shi still went downstairs out of humanitarian concern.

In the end, she found Zhao Xuning slumped on the ground by the Yujiang Bridge.

As luck would have it, snow was falling that day.

Snowflakes fluttered down, quickly blanketing the ground in a layer of white.

Zhao Xuning was not spared either—the white snow had turned her hair a pale color, making her look like a corpse.

Liang Shi was startled when she saw her and immediately ran over to help her up. The smell of alcohol was all over her.

Even with such strong wind, the smell of cigarettes and alcohol on her was still unmistakable.

The glasses she had been wearing when she went out were nowhere to be found. Zhao Xuning lay on the ground like a puddle of mud, without any will to live.

"Get up," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning didn't respond. She rolled over while lying on the ground, her white coat already stained with dirt.

This was the first time Liang Shi had ever seen Zhao Xuning so dejected, so disheveled.

"Zhao Xuning." Liang Shi squatted down and pushed her again. "What on earth happened?"

Zhao Xuning sniffled and sat up, leaning against a bridge pillar. Suddenly she murmured, "A-Hui?"

Tender and gentle.

But she had called out to the wrong person, and hearing it gave Liang Shi goosebumps all over.

Liang Shi pushed her again. Zhao Xuning was too drunk to sit steadily; one push from Liang Shi and she nearly toppled over, so Liang Shi had to reach out and push her back upright.

Pushing and propping—it was like playing with a roly-poly toy.

Liang Shi sighed helplessly. "Come on, I'll take you home."

Zhao Xuning was probably cold. She curled up her legs, hugged her knees, and rested her head on them, her hair falling all around her.

If those gossipy little nurses at the hospital saw this, their jaws would surely drop.

"I don't have a home anymore." Zhao Xuning said, "Where would I even have a home?"

Zhao Xuning's voice was choked with sobs.

Liang Shi pulled at her. "I'll take you to my place."

"I want my home," Zhao Xuning said.

A drunk Zhao Xuning was especially stubborn and wouldn't listen to reason.

Liang Shi was only wearing pajamas with a coat casually thrown over them—not warm at all.

She was shivering from the cold, yet Zhao Xuning was still throwing a drunken tantrum.

Though calling it a drunken tantrum wasn't quite right either. She was simply immersed in her own world, acting like a madwoman, a fool, someone lost in delusion.

She didn't ask Liang Shi to do anything.

It was only after a long while that she asked, seemingly lucid, "Liang Shi, can I win Shen Hui back?"

Liang Shi froze.

Before she could answer, the sound of high heels clicking against the ground came from behind her—*click-clack, click-clack*.

Against the backdrop of traffic noise, it sounded particularly eerie.

Liang Shi turned around and found that it was Shen Hui.

Shen Hui's eyes were red, as if she had been crying hard.

As she passed by, she nodded in greeting to Liang Shi, then walked straight toward Zhao Xuning.

Shen Hui didn't say anything. She just slowly squatted down in front of Zhao Xuning. "Let's go."

Brief and to the point.

"A-Hui?" Zhao Xuning called out softly, like a lover's murmur.

Shen Hui pinched her neck, and the pain made Zhao Xuning frown. "You hit me again."

The words sounded like a complaint, as if the two of them were on good terms.

But Shen Hui's face remained cold. "Get up."

Zhao Xuning shook her head. "I can't get up anymore."

Shen Hui stood up and looked down at her from above. "Then what were you doing tonight? Going to the shop and saying those things, doing those things—what are you trying to do?"

Zhao Xuning tilted her head up, and tears slid down her cheeks, melting the snowflakes that had fallen on her face. Water traced a path down her cheeks as she murmured, "A-Hui."

"Don't call me that." Shen Hui's voice was choked. "Zhao Xuning, I'm asking you—what do you want to do? Answer me."

The howling wind swirled the snowflakes into a dance.

The streetlamps on the Yujiang Bridge cast a dim yellow glow, wrapping the snowflakes in that same hazy light before they scattered gently upon the world.

Chapter 165-2

After a long while, Zhao Xuning opened her mouth, as if speaking was extremely difficult.

Shen Hui stared at her intently. "Are you going to say it or not?"

Seeing that Zhao Xuning still had no response, Shen Hui turned to leave.

But Zhao Xuning grabbed the hem of her clothes directly. "I want to be with you."

Zhao Xuning's voice was very soft. After she finished speaking, she repeated it again: "I want to be with you."

Shen Hui sneered coldly. "Didn't you say you'd give me your blessings? Is this your blessing?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head stubbornly, still clutching the hem of her clothes, looking disheveled and pitiful. "I'm sorry, I can't do it."

Shen Hui only glanced at her sideways, then turned her face away, gazing into the desolate distance. Her voice was mournful: "It's too late."

Zhao Xuning asked, "Why?"

Shen Hui didn't explain. She forcefully pried Zhao Xuning's hand away and said coldly, "Go home. Don't come again. You don't need to attend my wedding either."

Zhao Xuning's hand fell empty, hanging frozen in mid-air, still maintaining the posture of clutching at clothes.

Just as Shen Hui was about to get in the car, Zhao Xuning suddenly shouted in a torn voice, "Weren't you going to torment me? You should keep tormenting me! Why are you marrying someone else? This way I'll forget you quickly. You have to make me remember you forever... You..."

At this point, Shen Hui suddenly looked back.

Those light brown, aloof eyes swept over coldly, yet there were tears in them, making her look tender.

"Right now..." Shen Hui said, "I'm letting you go."

Shen Hui's car drove away from the bridge.

Zhao Xuning watched as the car disappeared from sight. Tears streamed down her face, yet her expression remained blank.

Liang Shi's heart ached just watching.

She never expected to come out in the middle of the night and witness such a heart-wrenching drama of painful love.

She walked over and pulled at Zhao Xuning. "Alright, let's go. You'll feel better after a good night's sleep."

Zhao Xuning remained wooden and expressionless.

Liang Shi couldn't persuade Zhao Xuning at all. She could only stand there like she was being punished, keeping her company.

Many people had already passed by, looking at Liang Shi with strange expressions. Those who didn't know better might have thought Liang Shi had done something to her.

Liang Shi wished she could carve a few big words on her face—*This has nothing to do with me.*

After waiting for who knows how long, Zhao Xuning suddenly stood up on her own, brushed the snow off herself, patted off the dirt, pulled her coat tighter, and walked toward the residential complex.

Liang Shi followed beside her, offering what comfort she could, useless as it was: "Go back and drink some hot water. Take your time coming to terms with things."

Zhao Xuning sniffled. "I can't come to terms with it."

Liang Shi: "..."

It sounded like she was just being contrary.

But then Zhao Xuning added seriously, "That person is terrible. She doesn't deserve Shen Hui."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Huh? Dr. Shen's taste can't be that bad, can it?" Liang Shi said. "Maybe you don't know her well enough?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head. "No, that person was in our class. Back then... she tampered with my experiment data because of scholarship issues."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Why is Dr. Shen involved with someone from your class?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning: "...They work at the same hospital. That thing looks presentable on the surface but is a deceiver."

Liang Shi didn't know how she managed to fight off drowsiness and keep chatting with a drunk. But Zhao Xuning was trying her best not to seem drunk. If she hadn't nearly tripped over the low threshold when getting into the elevator, Liang Shi would have really thought she was sober.

Liang Shi wanted to take her home, but Zhao Xuning insisted on going back to the rooftop apartment.

After returning to the rooftop, she took off her shoes and walked barefoot on the floor. Even without turning on the lights, she could find her way to that bed without error.

As she lay face-down on the bed, she suddenly said, "I was quite a bastard. I wasn't good to Shen Hui before."

Liang Shi stood at the doorway and went to close the curtains in the room.

Zhao Xuning was still earnestly analyzing herself. "I thought too highly of myself. I don't talk much, and I have a bad temper. But I listened to her."

"I can spend the rest of my days making amends." Zhao Xuning said, "That thing is different. Who knows what she's after by being with Shen Hui? Is she after Shen Hui's money or Shen Hui herself? Will she mind that Shen Hui dated me before? Will she mind that Shen Hui was temporarily marked by me? Will she mind that Shen Hui had a miscarriage? Will she betray Shen Hui?"

Liang Shi went to get her some hot water while listening to her ramble on.

She thought she wouldn't be able to hear once she left the room, but Zhao Xuning followed her out to continue talking.

This was probably the most Zhao Xuning had ever spoken since Liang Shi had known her.

"I can't even guarantee any of that myself, but I know that thing has a bad personality. She even tortured and killed small animals. There used to be a stray cat under our teaching building. She lured it away with a piece of ham, then dissected it with a scalpel."

"At the time, I thought she must be really good at surgery—her hands didn't even shake holding the scalpel, and we were only freshmen! That thing is definitely a psychopath."

"Oh right, she also likes to litter. I once saw her spit out gum at the library entrance."

"Her face is the only thing that's somewhat okay. Everything else is a complete mess. Shen Hui has such a bad temper—she'll definitely fight with her."

"If they fight, Shen Hui will cry. When she cries..."

Zhao Xuning choked up as she spoke, then continued, "It breaks my heart."

"Don't be fooled by how gentle and agreeable Shen Hui seems. Actually, she has quite a temper too. If you don't buy her breakfast, she cries out of anger. If you don't listen to her, she twists your ear. If you raise your voice at her even slightly, she turns around and says you're being mean to her. You have to coax her, or she'll start crying."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi felt like she was being force-fed dog food.¹

Expired dog food, though.

She really wanted to record Zhao Xuning and play it on loop at her bedside tomorrow when she sobered up.

1. Dog food (狗粮): Chinese internet slang for public displays of affection between couples. "Eating dog food" means witnessing or being subjected to others' romantic displays, often making single people feel envious or uncomfortable. ↩

Chapter 165-3

By the end, Zhao Xuning was tired. She sat on the sofa hugging a throw pillow and said softly, "I ran all over half of Haizhou to buy this. I went to seven shopping malls."

Liang Shi placed the cup of hot water on the coffee table and stood before her. "Drink this first."

Zhao Xuning continued talking to herself, "You all say I'm going to suffer because of my personality, but I really tried my best. I... what am I supposed to do? I don't know."

Zhao Xuning pounded her fist on the pillow. "It was my first time being in a relationship too. I liked her, and I listened to everything she said. What exactly did I do wrong in that incident? I was going crazy. It hurt when I woke up in the middle of the night too. That was Shen Hui—I nearly watched her die."

Zhao Xuning's words had lost all logic by now; she was just saying whatever came to mind.

It was all complaints and grievances, anyway.

But this was also how Liang Shi finally learned the reason for their breakup. Apparently, that day Zhao Xuning had been invited to a gathering by a classmate of theirs—someone who was on slightly better terms with Shen Hui and had helped her with a research project before. So Zhao Xuning felt too embarrassed to refuse and went. Meanwhile, Shen Hui happened to have a deadline approaching and was at home busy writing her thesis.

What was supposed to be a group gathering turned out to be only four people, and one pair of them was a couple.

Zhao Xuning didn't drink any alcohol the entire time.

At the time, she felt something was off, especially since that couple kept making jokes about her and the person who had invited her.

Their jokes were quite inappropriate. Zhao Xuning quietly distanced herself from that person without making it obvious.

She avoided the alcohol, but she never expected that person had drugged the water.

It was a drug with hallucinogenic properties.

At first, Zhao Xuning thought the water itself was the problem. It was only later upon examination that she discovered it was the cup—the drug had been applied to her water cup.

After the couple left, that person asked Zhao Xuning to stay under the pretense of discussing a research project. Zhao Xuning actually wanted to leave, but she was half-pulled, half-pushed into staying in the room.

As soon as the couple left, she noticed something was wrong with her body.

But the drug was indeed potent—she didn't even have as much strength as the other person anymore.

For a few minutes afterward, she mistook that person for Shen Hui.

It was only at the critical moment that she was able to distinguish by scent. Just as she was about to push that person off the bed, Shen Hui pushed open the door and walked in.

After that, Shen Hui was so shaken by the scene that she ran out and collided with a motorcycle.

She was only grazed slightly and fell over, but who could have known she was pregnant.

Zhao Xuning told Liang Shi the whole story several times, asking repeatedly, "What exactly did I do wrong?"

"If I had known that would happen that night, I definitely wouldn't have gone."

After listening, Liang Shi simply handed the cup to Zhao Xuning. "Drink some hot water, or you'll catch a cold tomorrow."

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Liang Shi's words proved prophetic.

Zhao Xuning really did catch a cold—she spent five of the seven days of her New Year holiday sick.

However, after sobering up, Zhao Xuning moved. She moved back to the rooftop apartment.

The place where she used to live with Shen Hui.

On the day she finished moving and had everything settled, Liang Shi went over to her place to have a meal, bringing Xu Qingzhu along for hotpot.

Of course, Ling Dang and Sheng Yu were there too.

The two little girls played cops and robbers upstairs, running back and forth through the living room.

Zhao Xuning watched them and fell silent, but she returned to normal after a short while.

After living in the same residential complex as Zhao Xuning, the group became much closer.

However, Liang Shi and her wife were a couple, while Zhao Xuning was alone and busy with work. Liang Shi often saw Zhao Xuning leaving for night shifts.

When she went downstairs for her morning jog, she would happen to run into Zhao Xuning coming back from the hospital, and they would all go out for breakfast together.

Liang Shi didn't dare ask about her and Shen Hui again, nor did she mention Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui's situation to Xu Qingzhu.

It was just that one day, feeling particularly emotional, she asked Xu Qingzhu, "Do you think Shen Hui still loves Zhao Xuning?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded without hesitation. "Yes."

Liang Shi sighed softly. "Then why can't people who love each other be together?"

Xu Qingzhu suddenly paused and asked in return, "Did you know those two fell in love at first sight?"

"Mm... I suppose I knew that."

"The two of them seemed to have had no adjustment period at all—they went straight into the honeymoon phase." Xu Qingzhu said, "I only heard Dr. Zhao mention it once. Their relationship didn't follow the normal process."

Liang Shi said, "Doesn't that prove they're a match made in heaven?"

Xu Qingzhu slowly shook her head. "How can two people not need an adjustment period? They just never encountered any major issues. When they finally did encounter something major—it was somewhat extreme, yes—but they really did fall apart."

"When you're immersed in love, you can ignore everything. You might not even really know what the other person's true personality is like. It looks like you understand each other, but actually, you don't." Xu Qingzhu spoke while thinking it through. "They skipped the process of getting to know each other during the ambiguous phase. They got together too intensely. Then, after many years, they really did love each other—but they were also genuinely at odds with each other."

Both of their personalities were somewhat extreme.

Zhao Xuning was extremely reserved.

To say she didn't love Shen Hui? That was definitely not possible.

But she truly wasn't good at expressing herself and didn't know how to back down or yield.

Who knows how they got through all those years together, but when it came to major issues, she was just... silent.

If she could have apologized back then, yielded a little, coaxed Shen Hui with a few words—given how much Shen Hui loved her, they probably wouldn't have broken up.

But she didn't.

Shen Hui was extremely proud.

Her pride was in her bones. For small matters, she could let things go, but for major issues, you had to yield—otherwise, she would fight you to the bitter end.

What she wanted was precisely what Zhao Xuning couldn't give.

At the root of it all, whether in life or in love, both of them had previously had things go too smoothly.

After listening to Xu Qingzhu's analysis, Liang Shi suddenly felt enlightened.

"What about us?" Liang Shi suddenly asked. "We also seem to be... We won't go down the same path as them, will we?"

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her. "Have we experienced few major issues between us?"

Liang Shi: "..."

That was true.

Chapter 165-4

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When it comes to matters of the heart, it's like a fish drinking water—only it knows whether the water is cold or warm.¹

No one can make decisions for someone else.

Even though Xu Qingzhu had channeled her top-student spirit, reading many books and watching many dramas to thoroughly research the topic of relationships—even flipping through several psychology books specifically to understand intimate relationships—

She could only understand other people's feelings.

When it came to herself, she could only sit numbly and wait for her fate.

And occasionally resort to some underhanded means.

Liang Shi was quite emotional about it. She later summarized to Xu Qingzhu that this was probably a characteristic of actors—always being swept up in other people's emotions.

But she was also powerless to change it.

However, after Liang Shi returned to Xu Qingzhu's side, Xu Qingzhu's physical condition was good. Liang Shi accompanied Xu Qingzhu to the hospital for a follow-up examination, and the ultrasound the doctor took showed—it was a pair of twins.

At that moment, Liang Shi didn't even have time to bask in the joy of having twins. Instead, she was thinking—did this mean she had successfully exploited the bug?

Just as she was thinking this, that strange mechanical voice suddenly appeared: 【Do you really think our algorithm is that bad? The laws of every plane world have been tested and calculated multiple times. How could you possibly exploit a bug?】

Liang Shi: "..."

Then Liang Shi realized that even if she had exploited a bug, it would only have worked after a real divorce. But she had torn up that divorce agreement and thrown it in the trash after coming home.

So if this wasn't a bug, then who bore the damage?

System: 【Xu Qingzhu. Lu Jiayi also bore part of it.】

Liang Shi: "..."

"So it's all resolved now?" Liang Shi asked.

System: 【Yes. After this major node concluded, all events have been rewritten.】

Liang Shi understood it as facing a fork in the road—one path would be dangerous, while the other was absolutely safe, the destined path.

The pain was only in those first few steps and the process of making the choice. After that, there would be no more.

Just as Liang Shi was thinking, the system's voice rang out again, sounding smug: 【Oh right, according to calculations, the computational laws of the plane world were already rewritten twenty days ago. The balance laws have been corrected.】

Liang Shi: "?"

Twenty days ago—doing a quick calculation, that was the day she left the divorce agreement.

Going back further, it was actually when Xu Qingzhu raised the knife toward her, then ultimately defied the world's will and turned the blade on herself.

The system said exploiting bugs was impossible, so it had to be the latter.

The decision Xu Qingzhu made in that moment, defying the world's will—their children had almost not been saved either.

Liang Shi felt that the balance laws of the plane world probably weren't satisfied with just Xu Qingzhu and Lu Jiayi being injured. These two babies must have also borne part of it.

Personal will defying the world's will.

Just thinking about it seemed impossible.

But Xu Qingzhu was someone who excelled at creating miracles.

And she had actually done it.

Liang Shi suddenly remembered that phrase—*I will defy my instincts to continue loving you.*

This emotion made her whole heart ache and swell. She really wanted to go and hug her.

But the system's next words pulled her right back: 【Host, how is your evidence collection going?】

Liang Shi: "..."

【The original body is being well preserved in an interstellar ice coffin, while the soul is imprisoned in an interstellar prison. A harm level assessment was just conducted, and she still registers at 3S danger level. Under these circumstances, do you still want to file an appeal for her?】

Liang Shi nodded. "Yes."

System: 【Then you need to collect evidence as soon as possible. We will continue to monitor the original body's danger level. However, the good news is that the original body's harmful consciousness has somewhat weakened. There is hope that it will drop to 2S level within a month.】

Liang Shi commented, "That's pretty good."

System: 【...】

The system had nothing to say and went silent.

But the system's appearance left Liang Shi speechless for quite a while. She had tried so hard to exploit a bug, all for nothing.

She was so annoyed that she skipped dinner that day.

But she woke up in the middle of the night and ordered takeout with Xu Qingzhu.

The two of them ate while watching TV. When they finished, Xu Qingzhu casually asked, "When is your drama airing?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "I don't know."

The one most likely to air now was "Mo Xin".

Films aiming for awards usually got approved relatively quickly.

Liang Shi sent a message to ask Gu Yixue, and at four in the morning, Gu Yixue replied with a voice message: "Probably spring."

Less than half a year—that was indeed quite fast.

By the time Liang Shi saw Gu Yixue's message, it was already nine in the morning, and she needed to drive Xu Qingzhu to the company.

Gu Yixue's voice in the recording sounded somewhat dry and hoarse, like she had just finished smoking.

Liang Shi asked with concern: 【Are you abroad on your honeymoon? Why aren't you asleep at that hour?】

Gu Yixue replied instantly: 【I am abroad, but it's just me.】

Liang Shi: 【?】

In the voice message Gu Yixue sent, she was even laughing: "I'm here for a film festival. Shen Fenghe is still in the country. How could we possibly have a honeymoon?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Every single one of them was a handful.

Even without any dramas airing, her agent was still actively finding work for Liang Shi.

Having discovered such shocking gossip in the office before, the agent remained unflappable on the surface no matter how shocked she was internally, and she kept her mouth tightly shut.

She even treated Liang Shi the same way as before, without a hint of flattery.

But it was true that she was more lenient with her now. She didn't keep piling work on her like before, and only contacted her again after she had rested for so many days.

"Are you free tomorrow?" Chang Hui asked directly. "There's a casting director for a variety show who wants to meet you. Shall we meet at 10 AM tomorrow at the company café?"

Liang Shi agreed.

Although she preferred acting in dramas over participating in variety shows, she could understand her agent's good intentions. Artists needed to maintain exposure during days when they weren't filming, and acting on variety shows was actually the hardest.

You were clearly acting, but you couldn't let people see through it.

So when it came to decent variety shows, she would participate.

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1. "如魚飲水，冷暖自知" (rú yú yǐn shuǐ, lěng nuǎn zì zhī): A Chinese idiom meaning "like a fish drinking water, only it knows whether it's cold or warm." It expresses that only the person involved truly understands their own situation or feelings. ⇐

Chapter 165-5

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The next day, Liang Shi arrived at the café on time. Chang Hui was already waiting.

Liang Shi exchanged a few pleasantries with her, and Chang Hui chatted as usual.

She didn't treat her any differently because of what happened in the CEO's office that day.

She did ask some questions, though.

"You're already married, right?" Chang Hui asked in a standard manner.

Liang Shi nodded.

"How many years?" Chang Hui asked.

Liang Shi was taken aback. "You need to know that too?"

Liang Shi could understand the previous question. Nowadays, drama productions had promotional directions, like shipping actors with their co-stars. If an actor was married in real life, they would try to avoid that a bit.

This included variety shows and regular interviews—directors needed to review the script in advance.

The reason Chang Hui hadn't asked this question before was that she never would have imagined that a twenty-five-year-old, good-looking woman hadn't focused on her career but had instead gotten married at such a young age.

But later, after seeing her wife, Chang Hui understood.

It was normal. Meeting someone like that, who wouldn't get married?

Anyone who wouldn't marry would be an idiot.

Chang Hui answered in a low voice, "Considering your future resource connections, it's better to clarify things."

"Less than a year," Liang Shi said.

"So you're still in the newlywed phase." Chang Hui said, "Then how come..."

She suddenly stopped mid-sentence, almost letting her gossipy soul slip out.

Fortunately, her excellent professional qualities as an agent allowed her to hit the brakes in time.

But Liang Shi nodded at her. "We didn't divorce. Our relationship is back to normal. I don't want to exploit her, so try to avoid such topics in interviews. The furthest it should go is asking what type of girl I like."

Chang Hui nodded, indicating she understood.

Just as they were chatting, the variety show casting director arrived.

What she came to discuss was a brand-new travel web variety show called "Let's Go, Right Now." She was here to invite Liang Shi to be a guest for three episodes.

Because one of the regular guests had a difficult personality, they needed to carefully select the flying guests.¹ They had to be people with good personalities, since this show was positioned as a slow-paced variety show.

The director of this show was Chang Hui's high school classmate, so there was some connection there.

When it came to needing someone with a good personality, Chang Hui recommended Liang Shi without hesitation.

The casting director coming over was really just a formality. She asked what representative works Liang Shi had, and Liang Shi was momentarily at a loss for words. She said rather hesitantly, "I filmed Director Quella's new work 'Mo Xin.' Does that count?"

The moment the other party heard "Quella," her eyes lit up. "Of course that counts! Quella is a director I really like. I heard a long time ago that 'Mo Xin' had started filming. I didn't expect you to be in it. Which female lead are you?"

Liang Shi was appropriately modest. "I barely count as the first female lead."

Indeed, she had more scenes. Then she added, "But 'Mo Xin' is a dual female lead drama. The other lead's role is equally important."

The director was shocked.

She had thought this was a newcomer without any works, just using Chang Hui's connections to get some exposure on variety shows. She didn't expect her to be the first female lead of "Mo Xin"?

...This level of status was honestly above their little show's pay grade.

And so the few of them had a very pleasant conversation in the café.

Meanwhile, in another corner of the café, someone had been watching them the whole time, leisurely sipping coffee.

The person sitting across from her looked in the direction of her gaze and suddenly let out a low exclamation: "Holy crap."

"What's wrong?" Lu Jiayi put down her coffee and withdrew her gaze.

But the person sitting across from her, Gu Chunmian, said in surprise, "Why does that person look so much like that dead woman Shen Fenghe?"

"She's your fiancée, at least." Lu Jiayi said, "No need to curse like that."

"It's already over." Gu Chunmian gritted her teeth at the mention of Shen Fenghe. "She's someone else's wife now. Gu Yixue really has some nerve—she actually incited Ziwen to attempt suicide. Great, now she got what she wanted. My cards have been frozen, and I've been grounded for half a month. Damn it..."

Just mentioning this made Gu Chunmian furious.

At the time, she had just wanted to stall for time. She had finally coaxed Ye Ziwen, thinking she would get married and then divorce Shen Fenghe as soon as she got the Gu family inheritance. Who the hell would want to spend their life with a poker face? It was an eyesore.

But she never expected that Gu Yixue had actually gone to find Ye Ziwen.

To be precise, after Ye Ziwen finished filming "Mo Xin," Gu Yixue told her: "Do you think she'll be free after getting married? Once she's married, you'll be the mistress—someone who can never be brought out in public."

The Gu family was wealthy and powerful. How could Gu Chunmian possibly give up the Gu family inheritance for her?

After hearing Gu Yixue's words, Ye Ziwen called her on the wedding day, having already taken pills.

Gu Chunmian got back in time and sent Ye Ziwen to the hospital to have her stomach pumped, barely saving her life.

But Shen Fenghe had already married Gu Yixue.

However, Gu Yixue didn't come out of it unscathed either.

Because she had snatched her sister's marriage, on the second day after the wedding, Shen Fenghe accompanied her back to the Gu residence. But because of an unexpected business trip abroad, only Gu Yixue was left behind.

The moment Shen Fenghe left, Gu Yixue was ordered to kneel before her mother's memorial tablet and was whipped.

Gu Yixue had been strong-willed since childhood. Even after being beaten so severely, she didn't make a sound.

In the end, her back was a bloody mess, and her black shirt was stained with blood.

She dragged her battered body out of the Gu residence, her spine straight as ever.

But Gu Chunmian was still angry.

Now things were great—she was being targeted at home every day. Her already precarious position was now even more perilous.

She was truly afraid that the bitch Shen Fenghe would help Gu Yixue rise to the position of CEO of the Gu family.

Because she hated Shen Fenghe so much, she found anyone who looked like her annoying by association.

Gu Chunmian glared indignantly at Liang Shi, who was chatting and laughing pleasantly over there, and snorted coldly, "Just a fake version of Shen Fenghe. Disgusting to look at."

Lu Jiayi glanced over without saying a word.

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1. Flying guest (飞行嘉宾): A term used in Chinese variety shows referring to guest appearances for a limited number of episodes, as opposed to regular/permanent cast members. ↩

Chapter 165-6

Only after Gu Chunmian had complained enough did Lu Jiayi say, "I thought you would choose Shen Fenghe."

Gu Chunmian frowned. "How could I? Ziwen was about to die."

"But if you don't get the Gu family, Ye Ziwen won't have much of a way out either.. and that includes you." Lu Jiayi said.

Gu Chunmian was taken aback. "What do you mean? This is a society ruled by law. What can they do? Not let me live?"

On matters like this, Lu Jiayi had always seen things more clearly than Gu Chunmian. She chuckled lightly. "A society ruled by law, but also a society with advanced technology. How many ways are there to make someone die in an accident?"

Gu Chunmian: "..."

After a moment of stunned silence, she could only force herself to say, "They wouldn't dare."

There were plenty of secrets among wealthy families. This was merely the tip of the iceberg.

Lu Jiayi found Gu Chunmian naive for actually giving up the opportunity to marry Shen Fenghe. People like them were destined from birth to be unable to escape this fate, so there was no point in struggling.

There was no need to even encounter love.

Love was far less important than interests.

Lu Jiayi had thought this through very clearly, which was why she hadn't been in a relationship for so many years.

However, Lu Jiayi wouldn't try to persuade Gu Chunmian, who had already lost her head over Ye Ziwen.

The two of them had met when Lu Jiayi was studying abroad. They got along well enough—as long as they didn't discuss relationship matters, things were fine. So they could barely be considered friends. And since the Gu family was one Lu Jiayi wanted to befriend, she could barely tolerate Gu Chunmian's love-brained tendencies.

It was just that she didn't like this kind of love-brained person. Having to constantly coax them after marriage would be too troublesome.

Otherwise, she might have considered a marriage alliance with Gu Chunmian.

Right now, she wasn't in the mood to chat with her anymore. They had met for an hour, and she'd listened to Gu Chunmian vent negativity for fifty minutes. It was very draining.

Lu Jiayi had been quite busy lately too. The recently acquired Huayi Media hadn't been restructured yet, and there were all sorts of miscellaneous matters. Her family kept bombarding her with calls every day, which was irritating.

So she made an excuse about having other things to do, stood up, and parted ways with Gu Chunmian.

After Gu Chunmian left, it wasn't long before Liang Shi and the others finished their discussion as well.

Lu Jiayi was standing at the entrance replying to an urgent message. When she finished and turned her head, she saw Chang Hui and Liang Shi.

Especially Liang Shi—their gazes met in the air.

Lu Jiayi was the first to nod at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi hesitated for a moment, then nodded back at her. Chang Hui obviously recognized Lu Jiayi and stepped forward to greet her. "Hello, CEO Lu."

"Hello." Lu Jiayi put away her phone and made polite small talk. "Having a meeting here?"

"Mm, we discussed a variety show," Chang Hui said.

Lu Jiayi smiled slightly. "That's quite nice."

Having been in the entertainment industry for many years, Chang Hui naturally noticed that the atmosphere between the two was somewhat subtle. So she tactfully said she had something else to do and left first.

And so only Liang Shi and Lu Jiayi remained.

The two stood at the entrance of the café. Wind chimes hung from the eaves, and when a gust of wind blew past, they rang softly—a rather pleasant sound.

Lu Jiayi looked at her. "Long time no see."

Liang Shi paused, then asked back with a somewhat confrontational tone, "Is that a good thing or a bad thing?"